

What if the woman you'd fallen deeply for turned out to have a dark secret?

PAUL GARLAND

TALES OF THE BLACK CATS CLUB

CAT AND MOUSE

A NO ANGELS EROTIC SHORT

Ben has been looking for the right girl for a long time and when he meets Jess, he thinks he's found her.

What he doesn't know is that the seemingly lovely Jess has a darker side. She works in a notorious strip bar and is more than just a pole dancer.

When he finds out what it is she does - and when she refuses to give it up - will Ben be able to accept Jess for who - and what - she is?

Cat and Mouse
A Tale of the Black Cats Club #3
By Paul Garland

A No Angels Erotic Short

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Foreword

If you've previously read '*The Bad Crowd*', one of my *No Angels* novels, you'll recognise some of the locations from this short - but this is a standalone book and you don't need to have read *The Bad Crowd* to enjoy this one. This story is set a year before the start of *The Bad Crowd*.

'*Cat and Mouse*' is the third story in the *Tales of the Black Cats Club* series and it ties into the first two, being a series but all three books are standalone stories in their own right.

If you haven't read *The Bad Crowd* and enjoy '*Cat and Mouse*' then consider picking up *The Bad Crowd* - it's a good read, even if I do say so myself.

I'd also like to thank fellow erotica author Lucian Cordray for his help with editing and proofing the book. Check out his work.

But for now, I hope you enjoy this; the third *No Angels Short* and the third of the *Tales of the Black Cats Club* stories.

Chapter 1

Four months after the events of ['The Cat That Got The Cream'](#)

"Jess?" I said, approaching the lady sitting by the fountain.

"Ben?" the woman said, turning to me with a smile. "You turned up. I wasn't sure you would."

"Ah," I replied, sitting down next to her. "So you've had that happen to you too. Nothing worse than being ghosted."

"You look nice," Jess said. "You didn't need to get all dressed up for me."

"I always like to make an effort," I replied. "I could say the same about you. You look gorgeous."

"Thank you," Jess blushed. She did look gorgeous though. Her mid-length hair was auburn but dyed blonde at the tips and it framed a pretty face with a hint of vulnerability in her large, blue, slightly-tilted eyes.

"I've booked a table for us at the Jupiter Restaurant," I offered her a hand to take. "So if you'd like to accompany me, it's only a short stroll away."

"I know where the Jupiter is," Jess answered after a moment, her eyebrows raised as she took my hand, letting me lead her away from the fountain. "I don't want to sound ungrateful or anything, but the Jupiter is expensive. I'm not sure I can--"

"The Jupiter is expensive, but you deserve something nice. Don't worry about the bill. It's on me and I can afford it."

"But I'm not even dressed properly for somewhere like the Jupiter." I could see anxiety etched on Jess's face and wondered if my grand gesture, aimed at impressing her, had backfired. The Jupiter was the best restaurant in town and was very expensive, but what Jess didn't know was that I was wealthy. Very wealthy. I hadn't told her that when we got chatting through Tinder, but I liked the fact that Jess liked me for who I was, rather than the six figures I had in the bank. Since my last wife left me after I discovered she'd been cheating on me with her boss (amongst others) I'd dated several women but each time, I'd made the mistake of telling them what I did for a living and of the comfortable life I had. It had become obvious

that this became the thing they liked me for, rather than anything else. I wanted a woman to be with me for who I was. Perhaps Jess was that woman.

"You're dressed fine. You look lovely," I assured her and she did. Jess was wearing a smart black leather jacket over a white t-shirt, a pair of tight jeans which showed off her shapely figure and a nice pair of white trainers. Sure, she was dressed casual but then again, so was I, in my polo shirt, sports jacket and jeans. "The Jupiter might be an expensive swanky place but you don't have to wear a cocktail dress to eat in there. We will be fine. I promise."

"I guess I have to trust you," she smiled at me and we walked the short distance through town until we arrived at the Jupiter, where we were met at the door and shown to our table.

"So how has work been the last couple of nights?" I asked after we'd given the waiter our order and were sitting enjoying a glass of white wine.

"Fine," Jess shrugged. "The supervisor I was telling you about hasn't been on duty, so I've been a bit happier."

Although this was the first time we'd met, we had chatted extensively for a few weeks since we first matched on the dating app. Jess had been embarrassed to tell me that she worked as a cleaner for a local gymnasium but I liked that. I was sick of dating high-powered businesswomen or the exact opposite - a woman that didn't work and was simply looking for a rich husband to be their trophy wife. I wanted someone like Jess. Someone humble and honest.

"What about you?" she asked. "Has it been busy at the bank?"

I'd lied - for the same reasons as before. I wanted someone who liked me enough to date me for Ben the nobody, rather than Ben the investment banker. So, I'd told her I worked in a bank, trying not to lie but when she probed further, I'd said that I was simply a cashier. And she'd been fine with that, much to my delight.

"The bank has been busy," I replied as our food was brought over. A delicious-looking steak for me and a healthy pasta dish for Jess. "But being busy is good. It makes the days go faster. It brought today around that much quicker."

We chatted more as we ate, Jess talking about her ex-husband a little more than I would have liked but I resisted the temptation to talk about my own past. I'd discovered in the past that talking to a woman about your ex-wife or previous girlfriends was a rarely successful strategy. Also, one of my life philosophies was to always look forward and not back. As much as was possible, at least.

"I've had a really good time," I said as we found ourselves at the end of our first date.

"Me too," Jess grinned, then leaned in and gave me a kiss on the cheek before getting into the taxi I'd ordered for her. "I'll text you later."

She did text me later, saying how much she'd enjoyed herself and how grateful she was for me spoiling her to such an amazing meal. I continued the text conversation and managed to get her to commit to a second date although she made me promise to something a little more humble next time.

The following week I was standing in the foyer of my local cinema. The weather was horrible outside, dark clouds hiding the setting sun, making it feel like night already. Heavy rain pounded against the glass of the cinema's front doors as I looked for her arriving, an umbrella at the ready.

I thought she wasn't going to turn up when finally a red Ford pulled up outside and Jess got out of the passenger side. I rushed through the revolving doors, putting the umbrella over her before she got too wet.

"Hello," she smiled at my courteous gesture.

"I thought you might cancel," I replied. "But I'm glad you didn't."

Back inside the cinema, I folded the umbrella down and looked at her. She looked even prettier than on the last date. She'd straightened her auburn and blonde hair and was wearing the same leather jacket but this time she had a dark blue dress which was belted at the waist.

"I don't wear dresses very often," she said, noticing me admiring her. "That shows that I'm making an effort for you."

"I dressed down for tonight," I laughed, looking down at my slightly-damp t-shirt and jeans. "Please don't think less of me."

We got popcorn and nachos and I let her choose the film - a romantic comedy which seemed apt for the occasion. I liked the cinema for dates because you didn't always have to have a sparkling line in conversation or then be able to hold that conversation for hours. The film did all the hard work for you.

After the movie - which was admittedly good for a rom-com (not my favourite genre) we walked to a nearby bar and enjoyed a couple of drinks. Jess was more relaxed this time than last. She laughed more. She talked about work and her ex-husband less. And as the evening wore on, I realised how much I liked her.

Jess still had zero awareness that I was wealthy. At one point I even lied and said I was glad we'd come to the cinema because the restaurant bill from the Jupiter had almost bankrupted me. That initially made her feel bad but then she laughed when she realised I was exaggerating.

"I have work tomorrow," I said reluctantly. It was past eleven at night and the barkeeper of the pub we were in had called time. "As much as I could spend all night talking to you, I should think about going home and getting some sleep. What about you?"

"I work nights," Jess finished off her last glass of wine. "We clean the gym during the evenings, late, after everyone has gone home."

"Of course." I finished off my own glass. "Do you want to share a taxi home? My place is the same direction from here as you."

She'd told me that she didn't live far from the cinema. I could drop her off first and it also meant I'd get to spend another twenty minutes or so in her company.

"Sure," Jess said. "I guess it saves some money for us too. We can split-"

"I'm paying for it," I interrupted. "I might not be Warren Buffett but I can afford a taxi home."

We talked more on the way home in the cab; about how we'd enjoyed the film and the night in general, until we arrived outside Jess's house, a modest mid-terraced place on a quiet side road.

"It's a shame tonight had to end," Jess said, putting a hand on my knee. "I hope I'm not being too forward, but why don't you come in

for a coffee? I know you're working tomorrow but you could just stay for an hour. One drink?"

Was she inviting me in for a drink, or for more? It felt like the latter and I wasn't going to say no.

As we got inside, out of the rain which had started up yet again, Jess closed the door and stood there for a moment, just looking at me.

"I hope you don't think anything of me inviting you in," she started. "I thought it'd be nice to spend a bit more time together. That's all."

"Of course," I smiled reassuringly. "I mean we haven't even kissed yet, so I wasn't reading anything into you inviting me in."

Jess's blue eyes considered me. She still hadn't moved from the door. "No, we haven't even kissed yet, have we? Perhaps we should change that?"

"Perhaps we should?" I took a step towards her and she did likewise. Our lips met and we kissed passionately, Jess struggling to take her leather jacket off while not breaking the kiss.

"Let's skip the coffee," she murmured, pushing me backwards and up the stairs, kissing me and undoing my jeans button and zipper on the way. When I stumbled into her bedroom and fell back on the bed, she was on top of me straight away, kissing me hard before sliding down my body to pull my jeans and shorts down.

It was dark in the bedroom. We hadn't stopped to switch the light on, but I could see enough from the street lighting drifting in through the windows. I felt a moment of anxiety as she first touched my already-erect penis because I knew I was smaller than the average man. I didn't have a micro-penis but I was on the smaller side. My ex had taken great glee in pointing that out to me when our relationship soured.

But if Jess was at all bothered about my lack of size, she didn't show any sign. She stroked me with one hand while watching me take off my shirt, then she lowered her head and took me in my mouth.

It had been over two months since I'd last had sex and the feeling of her warm mouth around my rock-hard dick was exquisite. I let her

give me head for a few minutes, then because I didn't want to embarrass myself by cumming prematurely in her mouth, I got up and lifted her face to look at me.

"My turn," I said and Jess didn't make any attempt to resist as I lifted her up and lay her down on the bed. I kicked off my shorts and jeans which were still hanging from one ankle, then undressed her, pulling off her dress first before sliding down her black panties while she took off the matching bra.

Her body was amazing. I don't know what I'd expected, but it wasn't the surprisingly-toned goddess I saw before me in the dim light. Her breasts were of an average size and were pert for a woman in her early thirties. Her stomach was flat, with a hint of abdominal muscle and her hips and thighs were equally toned. Her pussy was completely shaved and looked delicious, so I made myself comfortable between her legs and kissed her soft mound first, then delved with my tongue into her wet folds.

Jess's hands went to the back of my head as her thighs opened wider and I felt her clit swell when I sucked it and licked in small swirling circles around it with my tongue. As she orgasmed, she grabbed my hair, tugging (quite painfully) until I got the message and moved my body over hers.

"Make love to me," she whispered, so I let the end of my cock push against her wetness before pausing.

"Should I put a condom on?" I asked softly.

"I'm on the pill. It's fine." Jess put her hands on my backside and tilted her hips, pushing against me while pulling my cock into her.

I made love to her, enjoying the smell of the perfume on her neck as I kissed it. I thrust inside her faster and she responded, moaning sexily and digging her nails into my back at one point.

A short while later, I felt myself getting close. My thrusts were slower but harder and made her groan even louder.

"Should I cum inside?"

"Inside, yes," she kissed me hungrily. "Cum in me."

I did, ramming into her as deeply as I could with my modest length and then holding myself inside, savouring the moment as we connected in that way, my cum spilling into her.

“That was amazing,” I panted, still out of breath a couple of minutes later.

We were laying together, both naked on top of the bed.

“It was,” Jess giggled. “I hope you don’t think less of me for sleeping with you on the second date.”

“Don’t be silly.” I looked sideways at her. “We might only be on our second date but we’ve been chatting online for how long now? A month? We’ve got to know each other quite well and we’re not young kids. We’re adults. We kind of know what we’re doing. What we’re letting ourselves in for.”

“Do we?” Jess sighed, looking up at the ceiling. “I wonder if we ever actually know what we’re doing. I certainly don’t. My entire life sometimes feels like I’m making it all up as I go along.”

“Living day-to-day isn’t such a bad thing,” I replied. I was the opposite. I always had everything planned. I was Mr Organised. But I wasn’t going to tell Jess that right now. “Instead of seeing it as *‘you’re making it all up as you go along,’* as you just put it, instead see it as *‘living on the edge’* instead. You’re living life as an adventure, rather than a planned-out tour.”

“That’s one way of looking at it,” she smiled again. “Look, I don’t want to appear rude or that I’m telling you to go, but I don’t want you to be late for work.”

“Oh, right, yes.” I looked at my watch; the only thing I was actually wearing at that moment. It was half past midnight. I had a big meeting tomorrow and didn’t want to be too tired. I thought about asking if I could stay the night, but Jess was right. I should go. I didn’t want to push my luck.

I ordered a taxi and got dressed while Jess wrapped a dressing gown around herself and walked me to the door when it arrived. We kissed again, this time softer and more intimately.

“I really enjoyed tonight,” she said. “Have a good day at work tomorrow. I’ll text you.”

“I had the best time too.” I waved as she closed the door. It was true. I’d just had the best night I’d had for a long, long time. It felt almost too good to be true.

I didn’t know it at the time, but it was.

Chapter 2

Our third meet was just a lunch date. I was busy with work during the day and Jess's cleaning job was nights and none of the evenings we had free worked out for the both of us, so a midday was all we could do.

Jess looked lovely as usual - casual in a t-shirt and jeans whereas I was wearing my work suit, so I felt a little overdressed in the burger place we went to. Our conversation didn't flow quite as well as it had done the previous two times and we'd also not chatted online quite as fluidly since that night together, so I wondered if she felt weird or something.

"No, I don't feel weird at all," she replied over the top of her drink as she took a sip. "What do you mean?"

"You know how, sometimes, when you've been intimate with someone for the first time," I tried to explain, "There's a bit of tension because you've seen the other person naked and it sort of feels weird?"

"You feel weird because you've seen me naked?" Jess laughed. "I think I know what you mean, but I promise I don't feel like that at all. I've been around the block too many times. It was just sex. I had a good time. If you feel weird though, you can talk about it?"

"No, I don't feel weird," I laughed too. "I just didn't know if you did."

We settled into a slightly awkward silence after that and I cursed myself for ever bringing any of that up. I liked Jess and didn't want anything to go wrong.

Luckily, the dinner date ended shortly after that before I could get any weirder about things. I had to get back to the office but we made plans to get together the following Friday evening for another cinema date.

Everything seemed fine but then on the Friday afternoon, Jess called me to cancel, explaining that she had a few personal problems with family and I told her I totally understood. She hadn't talked much about her family, but I made a mental note to perhaps invite her to talk about it when we next met.

That was scheduled for another dinner date a couple of days later because Jess was working over the weekend but again, she called me an hour before to cancel, this time blaming a headache.

Again, we moved the dinner date back a few days and again she cancelled. Her texts and online chats had become more infrequent and I started to sense what was going on here. I was being blown out.

I wasn't sure what I'd done wrong. Perhaps I just wasn't her type but i didn't feel that way because we'd got on so well, right up until we'd slept together. I didn't have any other women that I liked, so I decided to just see what happened. If she stopped getting in contact at all, then it was what it was.

I managed to get her to talk to me slightly more one evening and even got her to commit to another cinema date, then that night, as I finished work, a couple of hours before we were due to meet, I sent her a text.

'If you're going to cancel again,' I typed, wondering how best to word what I wanted to say. 'I'm going to presume you don't want to see me again, so please try not to cancel.'

I added a smiley face to the end and hit send. Did that sound sincere or sarcastic? I felt a bit sorry for Jess because I had the feeling that she wanted to tell me she wasn't interested but didn't have the heart to actually do it. Jess was a nice person, I knew that much. She probably didn't want to hurt me.

I got a message back a few minutes later and felt strangely nervous as I opened it.

'I won't cancel but can we go somewhere quiet rather than the cinema?' the message read. 'I need to talk to you.'

Well, that definitely sounded like I was getting gently dumped. She just wanted to do it in person rather than by text, which was admirable, I supposed.

Should I save her the hassle? I didn't actually know that she *was* going to dump me, so I gave her the benefit of the doubt and suggested that we meet in the park by the fountain, where we first met. We could walk and talk and then if she was hungry, I'd take her somewhere for a bite to eat.

‘As long as it’s not the Jupiter, fine,’ she replied. ‘8pm.’

I arrived at the fountain at exactly that time to find Jess already there. The night was chilly - it was late October and the weather was turning - so she was wearing a woolly hat, from which spilled different coloured hair than what she’d had the last time we met.

“Your hair is purple,” I commented. “I like it.”

“It’s not quite purple,” Jess replied, looking down at where it hung over one shoulder. “It’s supposed to be violet but it didn’t go over the red and blonde colour I had before very well.”

It was a dark purplish-brown but it shone reddish in the streetlights above the fountain as I sat next to her.

“How have you been?” I asked with a smile. “It’s been a while since I last saw you.”

“I know and I’m sorry,” she replied, then took my hand in one of her gloved hands. “Shall we take a walk in the park? I want to talk to you.”

“That’s why we’re here - to talk.” I nodded and let her guide me away from the fountain into the small grassy park that led down the hill away from the city centre.

“I love this time of year.” Jess kicked her booted feet through a pile of red and gold leaves. “Even at night, the colours are so pretty.”

“Autumn is my favourite season too,” I agreed. “I love everything about it and it’s my birthday season too. In just two weeks.”

“Your birthday is in two weeks?” Jess paused as if she was going to say something then turned to me. “Look. I really like you, Ben, but I guess I’ve been kind of avoiding you a bit lately. I’m really sorry.”

“I guessed that,” I shrugged. “If you don’t want to see me anymore, you can just tell me. I’m a grown man. I’ve been dumped before. You don’t have to feel bad.”

“I’m not dumping you,” Jess squeezed my hand and started walking again, leading me onto the cobbled path that led to the small flower garden. “It’s just... you don’t know much about me.”

“That’s kind of why we’re going on dates,” I replied. “So we can get to know each other better, right?”

“I’m worried that you’ve got this impression of me as this cute, lovely person,” Jess continued as we passed the less-than colourful

bedraggled flowers. "But I'm not, Ben. I'm not cute or lovely or anything like that. I'm really not."

"That's for me to decide," I squeezed her hand back.

"There's things about me you don't know," Jess shook her head. "And I don't know if I'm ready to tell you yet. When we slept together the other week, it was nice but I immediately felt like I'd let you in... like, I'd allowed you to like me, before you even really know me. And that's not fair. You're a nice guy."

"So you *are* dumping me," I laughed, trying to lighten the mood a little. "You're giving me the '*it's not you, it's me*' line."

"I'm really not," Jess said. She looked upset, so I didn't push the joke any further. "I'm just saying I need to slow things down while I work this out. I like you. I really do. I'm just not sure I deserve a guy like you."

"You don't know me that well either," I said to her with an equally serious tone in my voice. "How do you know I'm a nice guy? You've chatted to me online some, met me four times. Slept with me once. That's not much. For all you know, I could be an axe murderer playing some sort of long game."

"You don't have the arms for an axe-murderer," Jess smiled, which was a relief. "I've seen you naked, remember?"

She had seen me naked and while I hadn't pondered on it too much, a part of me had wondered if my smaller-than-average penis had put her off seeing me. I wasn't going to ask her though. No woman liked insecurity in a man.

"It's not a big axe," I said, making a dick reference to see if she picked up on it. "It's more of a small hatchet, but it does the job. It's not the size of the axe, it's what you do with it."

If Jess had any issues with my size, perhaps she'd pick up on the subtle reference but she didn't. She just laughed.

"Why don't you take me for the bite to eat that you promised?" she said, a reassuring smile on her face.

I took her to a cheap-and-cheerful Chinese restaurant across the road from the park and we talked some more, in-between laughing at each other's incompetence with chopsticks.

“So, talk,” I encouraged Jess as I tried to work a prawn onto my chopsticks. “Tell me why you don’t deserve someone like me. What’s so bad about Jess?”

“I’m moody,” Jess replied, around a mouthful of noodles. “I’m impatient. I’m messy. I’m broke.”

“Find me a woman that isn’t moody,” I shrugged. “I quite like moody. It keeps a man on his toes. Impatient is okay. I’m impatient too, believe it or not. I can live with you being messy. I’m a habitual tidier, so it’ll keep me busy. I couldn’t care less about you being broke. Money means nothing to me. I like you for who you are. That’s what’s important.”

“But you don’t know who I am yet,” Jess’s blue eyes roamed my face. “That’s the thing. You only know the Jess that I’ve allowed you to see. There’s so much about me that you don’t know and I’m worried you won’t like it when you see the real me.”

“We all have a past,” I said slowly, trying to get her to open up. “Especially when you’re in your thirties like we are. We both have ex-partners. They’re exes for a reason. Some shit went down, obviously. I’m not sitting here thinking you’re an angel, Jess. You can tell me anything. I won’t judge. I’m not in a position to.”

I wasn’t. My ex-wife and I had split up in acrimonious circumstances; as much my fault as hers although I hadn’t seen it that way at the time.

“I don’t know...” Jess sighed. “I’m not good at talking about myself. I hate it. I can’t stand people either feeling sorry for me or judging me. It sometimes just seems that keeping things to yourself is the best way.”

“I understand that,” I nodded. I’d kept the fact that I was wealthy from Jess so far as well as the majority of the less-than-memorable moments from my past.

“So, if you promise not to fall for me,” Jess caught my eyes and held them with a serious vibe to her voice. “If you promise not to get too involved too fast, we can still see each other. If you want something more than that - if you’re not willing to wait for me to work my head out - then I understand.”

"I'm in no rush," I told her. "Whatever it is you're keeping to yourself for now - and I'm sure it can't be anything *that* bad - take as long as you want. When it feels right to talk to me about it, you can."

"I told you about Brett," Jess said softly. "My ex-husband?"

She had. She'd talked about him a lot. More than I liked, but I put that down to first-date nerves. Sometimes you just found yourself blabbering about whatever came into your head, tactful or not.

"You mentioned that he was a bit of a dick," I nodded sympathetically. "That he had a drug habit and it ended up ruining your marriage."

"Exactly," Jess nodded. "I did some drugs too, but it was always just recreational. I never did the hard stuff, heroin or anything like that. It never became a habit. I didn't even enjoy it. I just did it because Brett did, you know?"

"So that's it?" I raised an eyebrow. "You thought I wouldn't like you because you did drugs when you were young? Who hasn't?"

"Have you?" Jess cocked an eyebrow at me.

"I did a little weed," I laughed. "At university, but that's all. Even so, I'm not going to be put off you because you popped some pills and did a few lines of cocaine."

"Cool. Well, that's not it. There's more." Jess sat up straight and took a drink from her beer. "Brett and I are still in touch. He's a pain in the ass, but he kind of relies on me. He's clean from the drugs now - mostly - but he alienated all his family and friends. He's got no one to look after him. So, occasionally I go to see him - as and when he needs my help. He can't look after himself, Ben. He's an asshole who treated me like shit but I had feelings for him. I loved him. I don't anymore, but I can't just kick him to the kerb. I don't know what would happen to him, if I did."

"You're divorced, right?" I asked and when Jess nodded, I reached across the table and took her hand. "Look, if you tell me it's over between you, I believe you. I know a lot of men have trust issues, and because of the way me and my wife split up, I *should* have trust issues. I'll tell you about that one day, when I'm ready. But I'm willing to trust you. If Brett needs your help, that's cool. I'm not going to stop you from seeing him, okay?"

Jess stared at me, studying me. "You're so good, Ben. You really don't deserve someone like me."

"You keep saying that," I lifted her hand and kissed it. "But that's really for me to decide, and not you."

"Okay." Jess looked down at the table, deep in thought. "I'm going to suggest something. Some friends of mine are having an engagement party on Saturday. I haven't mentioned you to them or they'd have invited you, but I'm sure they won't mind me bringing you, if you'd like to come. You can meet my friends."

"Wow. Really?" I grinned. "I'd like that. I'd *really* like that."

"This is a big thing for me," Jess warned me. "Like, huge. I can't even believe I'm suggesting it. I haven't introduced them to a date for... God knows how long."

"I won't embarrass you." I winked. "I promise."

I called the waiter over and asked him for the bill and after paying it, I suggested an idea of my own.

"Why don't you tell me more about your friends?" I said casually, helping Jess into her leather jacket and then straightening the woolly hat on her head. "At your place again?"

Jess pretended to think about it for a while, then nodded with a mischievous smile on her face.

We went to hers and it went similarly to last time. Our clothes were on the floor before we even got into the bedroom, where we fucked urgently and passionately before I once again came inside her.

"I hate kicking you out like I did before," Jess sighed softly from the side of me. "But shouldn't you be going home?"

We'd fallen asleep afterwards and I looked at my watch to discover it was the middle of the night.

"Shit," I said. She was right. I was due at work in less than three hours and I had to iron some clean clothes and prepare a few things as I often did before setting off. "Okay. Don't change your mind about this engagement party. All I want is the chance to get to know you better."

"I'll give you a chance," she smiled sleepily. "I promise. Just remember. No falling for me, okay?"

“Okay,” I replied with a smile as I got dressed. It was hard not to fall for Jess. I looked at her naked body in the dim light. Not only was she a nice person and good company, but she was great in bed with an awesome, toned figure.

I told her I’d text her tomorrow and got myself a taxi home for a couple of hours of sleep during which I dreamt of Jess, of sex and also of my ex and how she’d fucked me over. Hopefully, Jess was nothing like her.

Later, I realised that dream was probably my subconscious trying to tell me something. It must have been picking up on the signs that I wasn’t consciously seeing. Or maybe I was, but I just didn’t want to see them.

Chapter 3

"Tim. Fran. This is Ben," Jess introduced me as we walked into the bar where the party was being held. It was more than just Tim and Fran's engagement party. Fran was six months pregnant, so they'd also doubled it up as a baby shower.

"Nice to meet you," I said, shaking Tim's hand and kissing Fran's. "I brought you a gift."

"Thank you," Tim replied, a middle-aged guy with thinning hair.

"It's only a voucher. I didn't know what to get," I said as he took the card I gave him.

"You didn't need to get us anything," Fran said with a huge smile. She was very pretty, blonde and curvy and her large baby bump only emphasised those curves.

"I didn't know about that," Jess said, squeezing my arm. "You should have told me. We could have got something together."

"It's fine," I shrugged. "I wanted to say thank you for letting me come down and meet you all."

"Well, like I said, you didn't need to but thank you," Fran replied then her eyes opened wide as she pulled the gift voucher out of the congratulations card I'd placed it in. "That's very generous of you," she said as she read the amount.

"Ben!" Jess said, as she led me away. "You really didn't need to do that. They'll be thinking I've latched onto a rich businessman for his money or something."

I'd only put a couple of hundred on the voucher. I hadn't spent a fortune. "I just wanted to make a good impression," I replied.

"Well, if you're *that* flush for cash," Jess said, as we arrived at the bar. "I'll have one of the fancy cocktails, thank you."

Cocktails in hand, Jess led me over to some more friends of hers.

"Mel," she tapped a short, dark-haired woman on the shoulder, causing her to turn around and almost drop her drink.

"Oh my God," she said, looking me up and down with large dark eyes. "Is this him?"

"This is Ben, yes," Jess replied.

“We had no idea you even existed until yesterday,” Mel smiled at me. “Jess is a dark horse, keeping her new boyfriend under wraps for so long.”

“We’re not using the term boyfriend and girlfriend just yet,” Jess told her friend.

“We’re taking it slow,” I explained. Jess had told me all about Mel. They worked together, cleaning at the gym and Jess classed Mel as her best friend. She’d met Fran and Tim through Mel and her husband, whose name escaped me but I was about to be introduced to next.

“This is John. John this is Ben,” Mel said. A late twenty-something guy of average height put his arms around Mel from behind first, before extending one for me to shake.

“Nice to meet you,” I said to the couple before they wandered onto the dance floor, leaving Jess and I alone for a moment.

“I need a moment,” she said abruptly, walking away briskly from me and disappearing out through the door before I had time to react. I stared after her for a moment, wondering if I’d done something wrong before a tall, striking red-haired woman stepped in front of me.

“So, you’re Ben,” the older woman introduced herself as Debbie. She was Tim and John’s boss but was also in the circle of Jess’s closest friends although she hadn’t been for long. “What’s wrong with Jess? Is she okay?”

“I think so,” I said. “I’m going to check now.”

I found Jess outside, smoking a cigarette.

“Yes, I smoke occasionally,” she mumbled. “Something else you didn’t know about me. But you do now.”

“What’s wrong?” I asked. “Are you okay?”

“I’m fine,” Jess replied, then put a hand to her face and sighed heavily. “No. I’m not fine. I can’t do this.”

“Do what?” I took her hand and guided her away from the bar entrance so she could talk without being overheard. Jess looked fabulous tonight in a little black dress and heels, even if she still had her customary leather jacket over the top. “Is it because I said we were taking it slow?”

“No,” Jess seemed upset again for some reason. “It’s not you, Ben. How many times do I have to tell you that?”

“Do you want to go?” I offered. “We’ve said hello to everyone. We can leave, say you’re feeling ill or something. I’ll even take you to my place. We can chill for a bit. Talk.”

“I can’t do that,” Jess looked up at the dark, overcast sky. “They wouldn’t ever forgive me. This is Fran and Tim’s night. I don’t want to ruin it for them by being a stupid bitch and leaving early, all because I can’t get my shit together.”

“You’re not stupid and you’re not a bitch,” I told her firmly. “I’ll wait as long as it takes for you to get your shit together, whatever that shit might be. Let’s go back inside, have another drink and just try to relax.”

“I can’t,” Jess looked like she was going to cry. “I feel anxious and... I just don’t... I shouldn’t have done this. I shouldn’t have asked you here.”

“Just stop,” I told her even more firmly. “Jess, I like you. A lot. Don’t worry. I’m not falling for you or getting in over my head too fast - or however it was you put it the other day. I fancy the hell out of you and I want to be your boyfriend, when you’re ready. But you need to talk to me. Tell me what’s bothering you. I can’t go on playing this cat and mouse game forever. Just talk to me. Let me help.”

“Cat and mouse?” Jess frowned at me. “Why do you say that?”

“It’s an expression?” I frowned back. “As in me chasing you and you dodging my questions and...”

“Did you talk to anyone while I was out here?” Jess asked, looking over my shoulder.

“No- what? Just Debbie, the red-haired woman you told me about but I don’t know what you’re asking me? I just said cat and mouse as an expression.”

Jess narrowed her tilted blue eyes at me. “Nothing more?”

“How can it mean more?” I asked. “What’s going on, Jess?”

She sighed and looked up at the sky again. “Ben, I really like you too. In fact, if I’m honest, I think I’m already falling for you and that frightens me. But it was nice to hear you say what you just said. I

fancy you too and I want to be your girlfriend. That sounds ridiculous coming from someone in their thirties, doesn't it?"

"I don't think so," I smiled.

"Let's go back inside," Jess decided after a long moment. "Buy me another cocktail. In fact, just keep buying them for me. Get me drunk. Maybe that'll give me the courage to tell you what I need to say."

So I did just that. I kept her topped up with Cosmopolitans and made polite conversation with her friends, telling them the same story that I'd sold to Jess - that I worked in a bank - and that we'd met on Tinder and been dating for a month or so. Debbie and Brad, her husband, seemed nice. They obviously had money too, judging by the Breitling on his wrist and the gold and diamonds dripping from his wife. Brad seemed strangely occupied by Fran's baby bump, constantly going over and stroking it, but Debbie didn't seem to mind, so I didn't pass comment. Fran herself was the centre of attention, so I didn't get much time to speak to her or her husband Tim but the good-looking Mel and her husband John kept coming over to check we were okay, sitting by the bar, as we were for most of the evening.

"Don't let her drink too much," Mel said quietly in my ear, later on that night. "Jess can't hold her liquor."

"I heard that," Jess leaned across me to talk to her best friend. "And you're too late. I am rather drunk, but I am happy. So you needn't worry. Also, I have my new boyfriend to look after me."

"I thought you weren't using the term 'boyfriend' yet?" Mel asked with a wink in my direction. She was incredibly attractive. She had a petite figure, toned like Jess and was wearing a tight black catsuit that showed off her slight curves nicely. Her wavy dark hair shone in the bright halogens above the bar.

"Well I just used it, so there," Jess stuck her tongue out then leaned in and kissed me unexpectedly on the lips.

"Yep, she's drunk alright," Mel rolled her eyes. "You should take her home soon. Before she starts falling over or worse."

"Yes, I'd like to go home soon," Jess's eyes shone brightly as she looked at me. "Did you say we can go to yours?"

"I did," I nodded, although I was wondering if that was a good idea now. I didn't want Jess throwing up everywhere. I turned to Mel. "Don't worry. I'll get some coffee inside her and put her to bed."

"You won't put me to bed," Jess giggled. "Unless you're getting in bed with me to give-"

"And that's enough information for one night," I laughed, cutting her off. "Come on. Let's order a taxi and get you home."

"Ben," Mel said, after I'd ordered the taxi. "John and I want to know if you'd like to join us for dinner next week sometime. It'd be nice to get to know you better. It's been a bit hard to talk tonight with all the noise and everything."

"That sounds great," I nodded. "I'd really like that."

"That will be nice," Jess added, trying her best to act sober and failing. "But you should have asked me first, not my boyfriend."

"I will call you tomorrow," Mel said, waving goodbye to her friend and leaving me to manage Jess's wobbly walk to the door for the taxi.

"I'm sorry I'm drunk," Jess said, once we got in the cab and were on the way to my place. "When we get to your house, we can talk, okay? Then if you still like me, I want you to fuck me really hard, okay? None of that love-making shit. I want it really hard."

"Shhhh", I grabbed her hand and squeezed it, then pointed to the taxi driver who luckily didn't seem to have heard. Jess didn't seem to have a filter, sometimes.

"I do though," Jess said then hiccupped. "I need it from you."

"Okay. Wait until we get in." I said, never feeling more grateful for small mercies when she was quiet for the rest of the drive. When I paid the taxi driver he gave me a lopsided smile that indicated that he *had* heard but had been gracious enough not to make it obvious.

"Your house is amazing," Jess said, as I opened the front door and led her inside. "It's so big."

It was hardly a mansion but it did have four bedrooms, a twin garage, a cinema-room and a small swimming pool on the back but I didn't show her any of that. I took her into the kitchen, made her a strong black coffee, then led her into the living room to sit down and talk.

“Leather sofas,” she observed, stroking the Italian leather with one hand as she sat down. “How do you afford a place like this, working in a bank?”

“My wife was from a wealthy family,” I lied. The exact opposite was true. My wife had come from a poor family and had only stayed with me as long as she did because of my money. “Her parents bought the house but I got it in the divorce settlement. She said she didn’t want to stay here. Too many memories.”

That part was true. I’d actually offered her the house but she declined.

“That makes sense.” Jess kicked off her shoes and wriggled her toes, then she pulled her legs in, sitting cross-legged on the sofa and looked straight at me. “So I’m going to tell you something now, okay?”

“Okay,” I smiled at her because she was so cute. Jess trying to be serious while drunk was adorable. “I’m ready. Hit me with it.”

“There’s a few things I have to tell you, but I am going to come out with this one first.” She took a sip of the hot coffee. “I’ll tell you the other stuff later, if you haven’t kicked me out.”

“Go ahead,” I reassured her. “Like I said, I won’t judge. I just want to know where I stand.”

“Last week,” she started, then corrected herself. “Well, earlier this week. And last week and the week before that. Or was it the week before that? I’m not sure. Anyway, I fucked Brett.”

I stared at her, thinking I’d misheard her at first but then she repeated herself.

“I fucked Brett.”

“You slept with your ex?” I asked, a nauseous, familiar feeling rising in my stomach. I hadn’t expected this.

“Brett is a fucking asshole,” Jess punched herself in the thigh. “And I’m an asshole for doing it. He needs looking after. I hate him half the time. I certainly don’t love him. I haven’t for years, but I can’t let him fall into the gutter. He forgets to pay his rent sometimes - and his other bills. I have to do his banking for him. The drugs, they’ve fucked his head up. If it wasn’t for me, he’d end up living on the street, or worse, he’d be dead in a gutter somewhere.”

"But you still sleep with him?" I exhaled loudly, wondering how the hell I was supposed to deal with this.

"I'm sorry." Jess set her coffee down and came over to the other sofa where I was sitting and placed herself on my knee. "It's just sex. It means nothing."

"That's not how relationships work though," I replied, avoiding her gaze.

"You see?" Jess said triumphantly as though she'd won an argument. "You said I wasn't a bitch and I am. I am a bitch. I'm a stupid bitch who's fucked everything up again. Like I always do."

"Did he force himself on you?" I asked her, trying to give her a way out.

"No," Jess shook her head. "He tries it on and he shouldn't. I even told him I'd met someone and he still tries it on and when he does, I always give in to him because as much as he might be a useless scumbag of a human being, he's really good in bed. I wouldn't have stayed with him for a long as I did, if he wasn't. His dick is huge and he just knows how to fuck me really good. I'm sorry, Ben. If you want me to go now, I'll go."

"I don't know what to say," I said, lost for words at this unexpected turn of events.

"All I know is that I think I've fallen in love with you," Jess said, wiping away tears which had suddenly sprung from her eyes when I finally looked at her. "I tried really hard not to because I knew I'd fuck it up. I knew I would. I knew I'd hurt you and I have and I'm sorry. I've wanted to tell you since it first happened and I thought I was being brave telling you now, even though I'm drunk, but I wasn't brave. I was stupid. I'm a stupid bitch."

"No, you're not," I told her, grabbing her wrist as she went to hit herself in the thigh again. "You're not stupid and you're not a bitch. You wouldn't be beating yourself up about it if you were. I just need some time to think about it, okay?"

"Take me upstairs and fuck me," Jess asked, putting her hand on my cheek and kissing me. I tasted the salt of her tears on her lips. "Fuck me all night. Then if you're going to dump me, send me home

tomorrow and tell me it's over and I won't ever bother you again. But please, just fuck me, even if it's for the last time. I need you to."

She sounded sad and yet frantic at the same time. I didn't know what else to do, so I picked her up in my arms, took her upstairs and pulled the little black dress off her roughly. I didn't go down on her. I didn't ask her to suck my cock. I didn't even kiss her. I just got naked, pointed my hard cock at her shaven pussy and rammed it in.

"Yes, that's it," she moaned. "Fuck me. Do whatever you want to me."

So I did. I fucked her as hard as I could, letting my anger at what she'd done fuel my energy and after screwing her like that for a while, I flipped her over and fucked her from behind, then I pulled out and eased the end of my cock into her asshole. When she didn't tell me to stop, I shoved it into her ass deeply, then fucked her anally until I eventually came inside her.

By the time I got my breath back, she'd already fallen asleep. I didn't know if she'd orgasmed or not and frankly, I didn't really care. She'd betrayed me before we had even gotten together properly. What did that say about Jess? About what type of person she was?

She'd been right. I didn't know her. Not properly.

And yet, when she'd said she loved me, I felt something inside respond. I had feelings for her too. Whether or not they qualified as *love*, I didn't know, but I did know that I liked her. I liked her so much that I didn't have the urge to send her home in a taxi and tell her to never get back in touch.

She'd found it in herself to admit the truth to me - even if she needed to get drunk to do it - but it still couldn't have been easy. She had a conscience. Perhaps she'd tell Brett 'no' the next time he tried to bed her.

I at least owed it to Jess to let her explain further tomorrow when she was sober.

I went to sleep, hoping that I didn't dream about my ex-wife again. My head was messed up enough already. I didn't need her - and the mistakes we made - haunting me again.

Chapter 4

When I awoke, Jess was gone. I was normally a light sleeper, so she must have been extremely quiet and nimble getting out of bed and leaving without waking me, but as I walked around the house that morning, there was no sign of her anywhere.

I checked my phone. Nothing.

I wasn't working that morning so there wasn't any great rush to do anything. I made myself a strong coffee and some toast to clear my slight hangover and sat down in the front room, wondering what to make of last night's revelations.

Jess had been drunk but I had no reason to think she was lying about sleeping with Brett, her ex-husband. Why would she lie about a thing like that? She'd gone on a self-hate mission, almost self-destructing in front of me, and she'd said there was 'other stuff' she had to tell me too. God only knew what this other stuff was.

So what did I do? Despite everything, I couldn't deny that I liked her, even after finding out she'd been screwing her ex the whole time we'd been dating. But that was the thing - we were only dating. We hadn't ever discussed sex really. There'd never been a conversation about us being 'exclusive' to each other. Or was I making excuses for her?

A message came up on my phone screen and I picked it up. It was from Jess.

I'm sorry I ran out on you this morning. I feel horrible and not just because I'm hungover. Can we talk or do you not want to hear from me again?

Did I want to talk? Or should I just move on from Jess? There was something about her. Something I couldn't put my finger on, something I liked. I wasn't ready to leave it here. That 'something' made me type a message back to her.

I'd like to talk. I don't want it to end like it did last night. When can I see you?

A reply came straight back:

Not today. I'm hungover and need to lick my wounds a little and sort my head out. I'm glad you replied though. I didn't expect you to.

I'm sorry for everything I said last night. Can we meet tomorrow so that I can explain properly?

We agreed to meet at a coffee shop nearby the following day. Jess had her dark purplish hair tied back in a ponytail and was wearing her favourite leather jacket and an extremely tight pair of jeans which hugged her hips and showed off her toned thighs beautifully.

"So here we are," I said, as I sat down opposite her with my latte. She'd already got her own coffee before I arrived. "We seem to keep doing this; meeting for a talk."

"I know," Jess smiled but it didn't quite reach her eyes. I could sense tension in her body language too. "I wish everything was simpler, but like you said, here we are."

"The other night was kind of crazy, wasn't it?" I started. I hadn't thought about what I'd say today. Normally, I was Mr Organised, but I'd decided to just go with my feelings and not with any pre-planned idea or speeches. It seemed the right thing to do.

"I was wasted," Jess shook her head, looking regretful. I wanted to get drunk enough to find the courage to tell you about Brett, but I guess I had a cocktail too many. I'm sorry."

"I actually enjoyed the night," I told her. "I liked meeting your friends. Then I enjoyed taking you back to mine. I enjoyed the sex too. It was just the bit in-between."

"I can barely remember the sex," Jess smiled awkwardly then laughed. "I'm not saying it wasn't memorable. I vaguely recall us going to bed, then I woke up, remembered what I'd said to you about Brett and just decided to sneak out before you threw me out."

"I wouldn't have thrown you out," I replied. "I've taken a bit of time yesterday and today to think and I'm glad that you told me. It must have taken some balls."

"It took a lot of cocktails," Jess sighed. "But yes, it was hard to tell you. I'm sorry I just came out with it. You're just such a nice guy. You deserved to know."

"I'm not sure there would have been a better way of telling me, to be honest. I'm just glad you told me rather than me finding out in some other way."

"I'm not completely sure exactly what I told you," Jess continued. "I was so drunk. I know I told you about him, but what else did I tell you?"

"You said he had a drug habit and that he can't look after himself. So you go to see him, help him with his banking and look after him so that he basically doesn't end up in the gutter. Then you said that he always tries it on and you give in to him and sleep with him because he's got a big dick and is amazing in bed. So, you just pretty much told me everything, I think. More information than I needed." I shrugged. "You also told me that you'd fallen in love with me."

"Ouch," Jess grimaced. "I really said that?"

"Is it true or was it just the Cosmopolitans talking?" I asked, nervous for the answer.

"I like you," Jess's blue eyes were wild as she answered. For the first time, she looked out of her depth talking about this. "I like you a lot. I think about you all the time. Like, literally all the time. I care what you think about me. I love being with you. I want to spend more time with you. I want you to be my boyfriend. Is that love? I don't know. But it sort of feels like it."

"Wow," I smiled, despite myself. "I feel the same, Jess. But after last night, I'm struggling to figure all of this out."

"You feel the same?" Jess smiled too, some of the tension visibly slipping from her. "That's good. If we feel the same way, whether or not it's love, maybe we can work out our shit? Together, perhaps we can figure it out?"

"I don't have a big penis, Jess." I just said it. There wasn't any point in beating around the bush. I needed to know where I stood. "Is that why you're still sleeping with Brett?"

"Ah. Um... That's a tough question." Jess seemed shocked that I was talking so bluntly. "No. It's not a reflection on you. Sure, you're not well-endowed like Brett is, but that's not the direct reason that I slept with him. It just happened."

"But if you're used to his big one," I reasoned. "You're not going to be satisfied with me, moving forward. Are you?"

"I promise," Jess leaned forward. "If we decide to make a go of it, I won't sleep with him. If we're properly together, then it changes everything. Brett will have to accept my situation and I think he will."

"But you'll still keep seeing him."

"I have to, Ben." Jess leaned back in her chair and sighed. "If you want me, and I hope you do, then Brett is something you'll have to accept at least until he sorts himself out or I can get help for him from somewhere else. You'll just have to trust me. If you can't, then I understand."

"I don't want to give up on us," I said after a moment of thought. "I haven't found anyone like you - someone I actually care about - for a long time. That means I have to give this a shot. I know I'll regret it, if I don't."

"I feel the same," Jess said. "When you turned out to be such a nice guy and I found myself liking you more and more, I almost gave you up because I know you deserve better than me and what I have to offer. But then I realised that how I felt about you meant something. It was worth something. I had to at least try to make it work. If I didn't, I wouldn't forgive myself."

"So, here we are," I said again, having a sip of my still-hot coffee and running a hand through my short hair as I worked through everything in my head.

"So, here we are," Jess repeated, looking equally as thoughtful as me.

"What else is there?" I asked.

"What do you mean?"

"You said there were other things you had to tell me," I replied. "Brett was one but there was other stuff you needed to tell me."

"There's just one other thing you need to know." Jess's blue eyes closed for a moment, then reopened. "But I think you need to do some explaining too, first."

"I need to do some explaining?" I asked, wondering what she meant.

"Yes," Jess leaned forward and put her elbow on the table, then rested her chin on her hand, staring at me intently. "Your house was impressive, Ben. If I remember right, you told me that you got it in

the divorce settlement from your wife who was from a wealthy family. I can't believe that. Before I left, yesterday morning, I had a walk around. You've got a swimming pool. A fucking swimming pool, Ben. Oh, and did she also let you have the Porsche that was hidden in the garage?"

"Okay." I'd been rumbled. "I don't work behind the counter in a bank but I do work in banking. I'm an investment banker. I'm comfortable, financially. I didn't tell you because in the past, once girls have realised I've got some money in the bank, they start liking me for all the wrong reasons. I wanted you to like me for me, not for my bank balance."

"You thought I was a gold digger?" Jess looked at me, aghast.

"No," I said, hastily. "I never thought that about you. I just... have... trust issues, with women, I guess."

"Perhaps you were right not to trust me," Jess conceded. "But I'm no gold digger. If you only knew the half of it."

"Tell me," I shrugged.

"You tell *me* first: why do you have trust issues with women?"

"I don't want to talk about it," I started, then realised that we weren't going to get anywhere if I just clammed up. "But if you must know, my ex-wife cheated on me. A lot. I gave her chance after chance but she kept doing it."

I was still holding back the truth from her. A truth I hadn't ever really confronted because I wasn't comfortable accepting it.

"And now you're worried I'll do the same with Brett." Jess's eyes softened. "I guess that's a problem you'll just have to work out, if you want to be with me, because like I said, I can't just drop Brett. I won't sleep with him - I promise - but it's up to you if you believe me."

"I can't let what happened between Michelle and I haunt me forever," I said slowly. "I have to try and move on. Try to trust you. I'm willing to give it a go."

"I haven't asked you this." Jess had moved, sitting back up and was tracing a finger around the edge of her coffee cup. "Have you slept with anyone else since we've been talking and meeting up?"

"No," I shook my head. It was the truth. Then I decided to be honest with her about something. Perhaps it might level the playing-

field. "The last person I slept with was a prostitute called Sara. The last couple of girls before that had been - what was the term you used? Gold diggers, that was it. I was horny. I needed sex. So, I went to a prostitute. Well, she's an 'escort' - a high-class escort, she calls herself. She cost a lot of money but I didn't want to sleep with some drugged-up or diseased whore off the street. But that was before we started talking."

Jess's eyebrows were halfway up her forehead and her pretty mouth was hanging open. She clearly didn't know what to say.

"So, there you go," I put my hands in the air. "Your lovely, perfect, Mr Organised, investment banker boyfriend, is actually a prostitute-using scumbag."

"I did not expect *that*," Jess replied when she eventually found her voice. "But I wouldn't call you a scumbag."

"It's your turn," I told her. "You said I had to go first. I've laid all my cards on the table. What's the one other thing you need to tell me?"

That wasn't quite true. There was still the other truth about my marriage that I hadn't told her. I was processing a lot of things right now. It wasn't quite the right time.

"I don't want to *tell* you," Jess replied. "I'd rather *show* you."

"What do you mean?"

"Mel suggested we all go out this week." Jess sucked in a breath, like this was a big deal. "She's been nagging me to tell the truth about where we actually work and what we actually do. So, I suggested we all go out together - tonight - and I'll *show* you."

"I don't understand." I frowned. "You want to take me to your workplace and show me?"

"Yes," Jess shrugged. "It's as simple as that. What do you say?"

"Why can't you just tell me?"

"Because if I simply told you," Jess explained, "You wouldn't understand properly. You'd make a snap judgement or whatever... it's just better this way. Do you trust me?"

"I guess so," I smiled. I had an idea what it was. She was a waitress. Or a bartender. Something like that and she was embarrassed about it, for whatever reason.

“Come out with us tonight,” Jess continued. “And afterwards, if you want to run for the hills, then so be it. Just give me a chance.”

I agreed and Jess left to set everything up with Mel and John and to get ready. We arranged a time to meet but an hour later, I got a text from Jess to say that John would pick me up and drive as it was a way out of town where the two women worked. I replied ‘okay’ and while I still felt somewhat uncertain and slightly nervous at what tonight might hold, I also felt positive and optimistic that things might actually work out.

I didn’t know quite what to expect, but what happened was something I’d never have expected in a hundred years.

Chapter 5

“We’re in the middle of nowhere,” I commented, looking out of the back of John’s car. “Where do you girls work? Are you secretly park rangers or something?”

We were in the countryside somewhere. I was a city person. I rarely ever came out into the wilds. The most I’d ever seen of the green spaces beyond where we lived was when I flew over it on my way to a meeting at the other end of the country or further still, somewhere abroad.

“We’re nearly there,” Jess replied from behind me. She was sitting in the back seat with Mel while I sat next to John in the front. He’d made a comment about my house when he arrived, saying it was fancy and Jess had told him about the swimming pool and how I’d hidden from her the fact that I was loaded.

Mel muttered how that was ‘convenient’ but I defended Jess, telling Mel that she hadn’t known until the other night. Right until that moment when I’d brought her home, she’d thought I was just an assistant working in a bank.

On the journey here, only a half-hour drive, Mel and John had made polite conversation, asking Jess and I how our relationship was going and if we were serious about each other. Obviously, Mel had only found out that I even existed the day before Tim and Fran’s party, so she was curious as to how we met and how many dates we’d been on. Jess told her right out that we really liked each other; that we’d been on several dates and even that we’d spent the night together a few times. Things *were good*, Jess said. She told them I now knew about Brett. We just had to get *this* out of the way. Whatever *this* was.

I was about to find out. We finally pulled up in front of a brick-built double-storey building which at first I thought was a country restaurant but then I saw the neon-lit sign outside glowing in the darkness of the cold autumn night.

The Black Cats Club, it read. I knew about this place. I didn’t know where it was, so I hadn’t guessed as we drove here, but I did know it was out of town. And I knew it was a strip bar.

"Wait," I said, as John turned the engine off. "You work *here*?"

"I don't," John answered the question which I hadn't directed at him. "I work in insurance, with Debbie and Tim. But Mel and Jess do, yes."

"I meant Mel and Jess," I looked at the two women sitting behind us. "I hope you're like... waitresses or bartenders, not..."

"Pole dancers?" Mel replied. "You hope we're not pole dancers?" Oh, *fuck*. Jess was a pole dancer.

"You promised you'd let me show you," Jess said, reminding me of the conversation we'd had earlier. "Don't make any judgments or presumptions until you see what we do, okay? You promised to give me a chance."

"You're a pole dancer?" I said in disbelief. How had she kept this from me? I thought she was a cleaner. "And you too, Mel?"

"Yes," Mel said. "Jess got me the job here when John and I fell into hard times financially."

"Did you know we've just come back from an around-the-world holiday?" John said. He had mentioned it. Several times actually and I told him so.

"That was paid for by this place," Mel replied. "Come inside. Let us show you what it's like."

"I told him he needed to see what we do," Jess told her best friend. "I said if he did this for me and decided I wasn't for him once he knows everything, then I'll let him run for the hills, if that's what he wants to do."

"I hope he doesn't," Mel replied while looking at me for a reaction. Mel was attractive. She had dusky-coloured skin with huge brown eyes and long, wavy, dark hair almost to her waist.

"Shall we go in?" John said, opening the car door. "Are you up for this, Ben?"

I opened the passenger side door and got out, looking at the neon-lit club and wondering how the hell I'd arrived at this point. Jess was one big surprise after another, it seemed.

"I've never been to a strip club before," I answered honestly. I hadn't. "There's a first time for everything, I guess."

“Let’s go.” Jess smiled and took my hand. “I’m really grateful that you’re doing this for me.”

I let her lead me to the entrance where a stunning Chinese-looking woman greeted the girls warmly.

“This is Ben,” Jess introduced me. “Ben, this is Annabel. She’s the owner’s wife and runs the Black Cats. Annabel, this is Ben, my new boyfriend. He’s never been here before.”

Annabel looked me up and down in an incredibly sexual way, her eyes lingering on the crotch of my trousers far longer than was socially acceptable.

“Jess has never brought a man here before,” the woman said, still looking me up and down. “Behave yourself and you’ll be welcome here anytime, Ben.”

“I will,” I replied, feeling strangely intimidated. The woman was short and slender but had a certain presence about her. After we’d left her behind, walking down a short corridor towards the bar in front of us, I whispered in Jess’s ear. “I bet no one messes around with Annabel, do they? She’s quite something.”

“No one messes with any of the family that owns this place,” Jess replied with a whisper back in my ear. “They’re criminals of the worst sort, but they look after the people that work for them.”

This just kept getting worse and worse. Jess was not only a pole dancer, but she worked for the local mafia, by the sounds of it. What the hell was I getting myself mixed up in?

“This is the main room,” John told me as we stepped out into a large, dimly-lit and darkly-decorated room. A bar served drinks on one side of us while on the other were two dancing podiums, one with a pole and one without. The one without had a topless blonde gyrating on it while the other podium featured a curvy black girl who helicoptered around the pole in nothing but the tiniest of sparkling thongs.

“It’s quite busy tonight,” Mel observed to Jess, who nodded, then came over to me.

“This is where I leave you for a little while. I’m going to get changed with Mel, then we’ll see you in *there*.” She pointed to

another door on the far side of the room, this one guarded by a huge bouncer standing by a velvet rope barricade.

“Okay,” I replied, trying to appear cool while actually being a bag of nerves inside. “I have no idea what I’m doing, you know?”

“Don’t worry. John will look after you.” Jess replied before leaving me to catch up with Mel who was already heading towards a door by the bar.

“Our girls work in the V.I.P. area only,” John explained as I watched the two women disappear through the door. “Like Jess said, don’t worry. I come here all the time and I’ll explain everything.”

We reached the second door and the huge man blocking our way gave me a look up and down even more intimidating than the one Annabel had given me earlier. He was as wide as John and I together, with a mohawk hairstyle and a gold tooth that glinted when he smiled at John and pulled back the red barricade so we could pass through.

“He was rather scary,” I said quietly as John led me into another room much like the first.

“Who? Dwayne?” John laughed. “Nah. He’s a big softie really. As long as you stay on his right side.”

“If you say so,” I replied as he took me across the room to the bar, behind which was a topless guy, all rippling muscles and whitened teeth. “What do you want to drink?”

“I’ll just take a beer,” I replied, looking around. The atmosphere in here was heavy. It wasn’t as busy as the main room we’d just come from, but the air was thick with fake smoke and the lights here were even dimmer. A pounding dance beat emanated from speakers in the ceiling. It felt sleazy, but in a good way.

“Ryan here is one of Tim’s friends,” John told me, pointing to the barman who was fetching our drinks from one of the silver refrigerators at the back of the bar. “He used to come here all the time and ended up working here as a male stripper. They have gay nights and ladies’ nights occasionally.”

“Ah, so you’re Jess’s fella.” Ryan said as he passed us the beers. “Nice to meet you. Jess is a great girl. You’re a lucky guy. Make sure you look after her.”

With that, he reached below the counter and passed me a handful of small black plastic tokens. I looked at them, wondering what they were for. They were cat-shaped. I held them out to John with a quizzical look.

“Pussycats,” he explained. “Tokens. You pay for private dances with them. You’ll see. Come on. Let’s find somewhere to sit down while we wait for Mel and Jess.”

In the centre of the room was a small stage with a shining silver pole and at the moment, an attractive Asian girl was dancing in front of it. As we sat down in a small booth right in front of the stage, she slipped off her red bra-top, revealing her small but perky breasts. Several customers behind us whooped appreciatively and one even threw a couple of the pussycat tokens on the stage.

“So they’re like a sort of tip,” I noted.

“You can use them like that,” John nodded, taking a sip of his beer while watching the sexy dancer. “There’s no cash allowed here. But also, the girls come around after their dances and you can give them a token in exchange for a lap dance. If you pay them more, they take you over there.” He pointed towards a darkened corner of the room. Through the illuminated mist, I could just about make out a series of partitions blocking the corner off from sight.

“What’s over there?” I asked.

“That’s the private dance area,” John answered. “There’s four sections, totally out of the view of each other and the rest of the room. There, the girls will give you a more explicit dance. They’ll get naked, rub their boobs in your face. Grind their pussies on your legs. If you pay them enough, they’ll even get you off.”

“Get you off?” I replied, my beer frozen on its way to my mouth. Did he mean...?

“You can ask for a handjob, a blow job, there’s even a couple of girls that’ll go all the way, as long as you don’t take too long to cum and you have a condom with you. It’ll cost you, of course.”

“And all the girls do these private dances?” I asked, not sure if I wanted to hear the answer.

“If you’re asking me, ‘do Mel and Jess do these private dances?’ then the answer is yes,” John said, bluntly. “All the girls do. Although

neither Mel nor Jess will go all the way with a punter.”

“But they do handjobs and blowjobs?”

John nodded.

“Until the customer... finishes?”

Again, John nodded. *Fuck*. This had to be some sort of cruel joke. It *had* to be.

“And you’re okay with Mel doing this?” I asked. “I know she doesn’t go all the way, but still - giving random guys blowjobs. You’re okay with that?”

“She does go all the way sometimes,” John corrected me. “But that only happens on special events. They’re held through *that* door.” He pointed towards yet another doorway which was guarded again by a bouncer.

“She does?” I took a deep pull of the beer, drinking half of it in one long swallow. I needed it. “What do you mean by *special events*?”

“There’s the Cat That Got The Cream night,” John replied. “That involves customers spunking all over the girl, like a big bukkake party, if you’ve heard the term.”

I knew what bukkake was. I’d watched enough porn to have happened upon it.

“There’s also the Nine Lives night,” John went on. “Which is one girl, nine men. It’s a full-on gangbang, basically. There’s the Cat and Mouse night where the guys stick their dicks through what they call ‘mouseholes’ but are basically glory holes. It’s random whether you get a handjob on the other side, or a blow job or occasionally you might encounter one of the girls’ hot, wet pussy. You have to pay a lot of money - a *lot* of money - to get in on the events. The girls make a lot in return for doing them. That’s how Mel and I afforded to pay off all our debts and then go on the holiday we’ve just come back from. I told you about the holiday, right?”

“Yes, you did,” I replied, for the third or fourth time. I remembered how Jess had frozen that time I used the term ‘cat and mouse.’ I knew why now. “So, Mel’s done... what? All of those events?”

“I always go in with her,” John nodded. “I wouldn’t let her do them without me. It makes me feel better about it. Plus, I kind of get off on

watching her with other guys. I know - you probably don't understand that. Heck, it took me a while to understand it and accept it, but once I did, I didn't look back."

"So, Mel's done gangbangs," I said to myself as much as anything, trying to absorb what he'd just told me. "Does that mean Jess has too?"

"I'll let Jess tell you in a bit," John pointed towards the podium. I'd taken my eyes off the Asian girl and not noticed her vacate the stage. "Our girls are on next. It looks like they're dancing together."

I looked through the mist and saw my Jess walking towards the stage. She was wearing a tight pink mini-top and hot pants that showcased her toned figure. Her hair was down and was sparkling in the lights as if it had been sprinkled with glitter. Mel was wearing a silver bra and panty set. The two of them looked as raunchy as hell as they climbed the small steps to the stage.

Jess grabbed the pole while Mel stood in a sexy pose next to her. Jess's head turned until she found me and her eyes locked with mine.

Then the music started.

Chapter 6

"You're in for a treat," John said with a wink and a reassuring smile as our two girls began to move on the stage.

At first I cringed, feeling awkward and out of place, not because I was watching Jess, but because I was watching John's wife. I should have felt weird that he was seeing my girlfriend but I'd realised he'd already probably seen her dozens of times in the past. He'd most likely seen her naked. He might have even had one of those private dances in the secluded area. Maybe she'd wanked him off. Maybe she'd let him cum in her mouth. Perhaps she'd even let him fuck her.

I shook the thoughts out of my head. There was no point in wondering. I'd ask John, but after the dance had finished. The music had grown louder and there's no way he'd hear me, even if I could distract him from the view in front of us.

Jess had one leg around the pole and was gliding around it gracefully, almost like a ballet dancer. There was something actually admirable in her movements. She showed great strength and coordination as well as being a pretty good dancer. Mel was simply dancing, alternating between gyrating her hips and dancing left to right and back again, like an old-fashioned disco queen. Again, she was a good dancer. I had to begrudgingly admit to being impressed.

Mel joined Jess on the pole for a moment, the two girls spinning around each other in an almost circus-like stunt, before Jess became the one solo-dancing while Mel worked the pole. Then it got to the *interesting* part.

Jess was the first to strip. She wasn't staring at me now but was instead working the crowd, looking left and right and whipping the men (and women, surprisingly) into a frenzy by slowly lifting the tight mini-top enough to show the undersides of her breasts. Someone threw a couple of the black pussycat tokens onto the stage, then with a spin on her heel, Jess pulled the top over her head and dropped it to the floor.

I held my breath for a moment, just staring at the woman I'd been dating for the past month or so. She was standing there - looking beautiful - topless in front of a room full of people. Her round breasts

looked firm - they *were* firm, I'd had the pleasure of playing with them, so I knew - and her dark pink nipples were erect, probably with excitement.

"Jess has got amazing tits," John shouted to me over the loud, thumping bassline. "I've seen them so many times but I never get tired of them."

Mel was the next to discard her top. She and Jess had both left the pole now and were standing back-to-back, asking the crowd for more tokens - several of which landed at their feet - and then Mel unclasped the silver bra top and let it fall free.

I didn't know where to put my eyes. This was John's wife, now topless in front of me. I glanced from Mel's smaller but equally pert breasts to her husband but if he was at all bothered by all the men in the room looking at his wife's tits, he didn't show any signs. I guessed he was used to it by now.

The two girls began to dance again, skipping around the stage before the final part of their act began. They danced in tandem, both perfectly in time with the music and with one another - a well-rehearsed routine. When they both bent over, showing their tight backsides to the delighted crowd, a shower of tokens landed on the stage and in response, the two women looked at each other and then slowly peeled down their bottoms - oh, so slowly - to reveal their naked asses.

"Are you okay?" John asked in my ear, startling me for a moment because I'd been so intent on watching the girls.

"I'm okay," I nodded then tapped my empty beer bottle. "I could use a refill, if you want one?"

"Yeah but let's watch the end of the dance first," John stayed me with a hand on my arm. "It's almost over. The pussy reveals, then they're done."

The pussy reveals. He said it like it was totally normal for a husband to use those words in reference to his wife.

I watched the end, the two women standing and twirling around, their bottoms pulled down enough to show the tops of their shaved bare pubic mounds and then finally, in time to the last beat of the song, they kicked them off, baring everything by kicking one leg high

into the air and holding it there as the music finished and the lights went out.

The crowd erupted in applause and lewd comments, some of which were vulgar beyond belief and as they calmed down and the lights came back on, the girls had collected their discarded clothes and the tokens from the stage and were heading back to the bar from where they'd come.

"What did you think?" John asked me, an excited look glistening in his eyes.

"They were... *good*," I replied, still feeling strange that I'd just seen this man's wife totally naked. I couldn't lie. The girls *had* been good. They were entertaining. They could both dance and their bodies were out of this world. I understood now why Jess's body was so firm and fit. Dancing on a pole - dancing in general - was good exercise.

"Let me get those beers," John replied with a pat on the shoulder. "I'll give you a minute to digest what you just saw. Your girl *is* a pole dancer, but she's a damned good one."

"Put your hands together again for Jezebel and Mia," I heard a female voice say over the speakers and turned to see Annabel walking through the crowd towards the stage. "The girls were coming around the room soon, so if you want a dance, get your tokens from the bar now."

My heart thumped hard in my chest. Jess was going to go around the room? That meant her doing private dances with the customers and John had said they sometimes involved more than just lap dancing. Was she actually going to do this - with me present?

"You're still here," John said, passing me another beer and sitting back down next to me. "I half-wondered if you might get up and leave. Jess is fully expecting you to walk out, you know?"

"Is she?" I scratched my head, trying to sort through all the information that had been launched at me this evening. Jess was a pole dancer and a lap dancer. More than that, she sometimes did paid sexual favours for men. Did that make her a prostitute of sorts? If so, how could I judge? I'd slept with Sara - and another of the same company's escort girls who I hadn't told Jess about earlier, a

gorgeous mixed race girl called Rachel. I'd used those girls just the same as the men here used Jess and Mel and all the others that worked here - for easy, no-strings sexual gratification. I looked around the room at some of the customers. Here in the V.I.P. side of the building, most of them were well-dressed - probably well-to-do businessmen and the like - just like me. In a way, I was no different from them.

"Talk to me," I heard John say, pulling me out of my head again. "What are you thinking?"

"I'm just taking it all in," I found myself saying. "It's a lot to process."

"If it helps you at all," John shifted closer, so he could talk quietly. "I had no idea that Mel worked here for a while. She told me she was doing a cleaning job with Jess. Tim was the one that told me. He'd been coming here for a while but with Mel being in the V.I.P. he'd never bumped into her. Then one night, he managed to get into this side and voila! He recognised Mel straight away."

"Wow," I said, genuinely interested in his story. "So what happened?"

"Tim didn't know how to tell me, at first," John took a long drink of the beer then recounted the rest of the story to me; how he hadn't believed Tim at first and so had come to the club to find out for himself. He'd watched Mel do a dance and then he'd witnessed her being covered in sperm by a group of men in one of those special events he'd mentioned earlier.

"So it was a baptism of fire," he finished. "Thrown straight in at the deep end. I went from thinking Mel was my hard-working, respectable housewife and mother, to seeing her get spunked all over by a bunch of dirty bastards, most of whom she sucked and wanked off along the way. All in one night. So, whatever you're feeling right now, I get it."

"I hope I'm not going to have to watch Jess get cum on by a bunch of dirty bastards tonight, am I?" I asked.

"No," John shook his head. "There's no special events tonight. That only happens one night per week and all the girls here take it in

turns to be *the cat*; that is, the girl involved in the events. Jess and Mel are two of the most popular though."

"So, Jess *has* been in these special events?" I asked, but again John refused to answer.

"As I said," he repeated, "You can ask her yourself. She's here now."

I turned to see Jess approaching our table. Mel wasn't with her. I looked around and saw John's wife already circling the room, walking from one table to another.

"Come with me," Jess said when she reached us. She was dressed again in the same pink top and bottoms. She looked genuinely worried. "If you're going to dump me, you can do it in one of the private booths."

I didn't say anything. I just let her take me by the hand and lead me away from a concerned looking John, towards the partitioned-off area he'd shown me before.

"I'm not going to dump you," I said as we rounded one of the tall black panels, turning into a small square area, dimly lit by one small spotlight in the ceiling.

"Don't say that," Jess replied with a sad look. "I know you are. No one like you wants to be with a girl like me. Especially once you know what goes on in these booths."

Jess pushed me towards a black leather chair in the corner of the booth, urging me to sit down, then she sat on the arm of the chair.

"I already know," I told her. "John told me everything. He said you bring the customers here, in return for payment in the form of these." I showed her some tokens, producing them from my pocket. "He said you give men handjobs sometimes. Blowjobs. He even suggested you might do more."

"That's right," Jess nodded, looking increasingly nervous.

"And he suggested that you participate in the special events they do. Bukkake, glory-holes, gangbangs."

"I have done in the past," Jess confessed, her blue eyes twinkling in the dim light, moist with what looked like forming tears.

"Are you going to give this all up for me?" I asked softly. "Like you said you'd give up sex with Brett?"

“Do you want me to?” Jess replied, equally quietly. “Is that what it would take for me to hold on to you? I don’t want to lose you, John, but I need this job.”

“Jess,” I took her hand and squeezed it gently. “You don’t need it, if you have me. I make enough money for the both of us.”

“There’s one last thing I haven’t told you,” Jess prised her hand from mine. “When I told you about Brett, the only thing I didn’t mention is that while we were together, he got into debt. Serious amounts of debt. Over thirty grand of debt. I’ve been paying it off for him by working here. If I give this job up, Ben, they’ll kill him. I’m not even exaggerating.”

“Drug debt?” I guessed. “To his dealers?”

“He was selling before he was using,” Jess shook her head. “I won’t pretend to know all the ins-and-outs but yes, he got massively in debt. The more in debt he got, the worse his habit became. He was using drugs to escape the stress of being in debt. It became a vicious circle, as often happens. The debt; his using; it split us up. But after they threatened to kill him when he told them he couldn’t pay up, I knew I had to somehow help him. So I took this job here as a way to make some quick and easy cash.”

“Let me help,” I said, appalled at what she was telling me.

“I’m not going to let anyone else get involved, including you,” Jess insisted firmly. “Brett is my problem. I make good money here, Ben. I’ll have them paid off in the next year, maybe less. Then I can work on getting him cleaned up. I think once the debt is off his mind, when he knows it’s over, he’ll be able to sort himself out.”

“But that’s crazy,” I replied. “Thirty grand is a lot of money but I can afford it, Jess. Let me help. You don’t have to work here any more.”

“I’m not letting you help, Ben!” Jess almost shouted at me. “I don’t care how rich you are. No. You’re a good man but I’m not going to let you think I’m a gold digger. And besides, I work here because I enjoy it. I don’t want to give it up. Even once I’ve paid Brett’s dealers off, I’ll probably still work here.”

“You enjoy it?” I looked at Jess. “You like being a prostitute? Which is basically what you are.”

"You fucked a prostitute before you met me," Jess reminded me. "Escorts are prostitutes, however they label themselves. They're no better than me, no matter how much they charge."

"True," I nodded. "But still. I don't know why you'd do this when you don't have to?"

"As I said," Jess shrugged, her breasts bouncing, even in the tight top she was wearing. "I enjoy it. I like men looking at my body. I like them lusting after me. I like making them cum. If you haven't worked it out yet, Ben, I like sex. I always have. Before I got with Brett, I slept with a lot of men. And some girls. I've always had a high sex drive."

"Wow," I said, shaking my head in disbelief. "When you said there was a lot I didn't know about you, you weren't kidding."

"Go on then," Jess said after a moment of silence between us. "Fuck off home. I'll save you the trouble of telling me what a slut I am and how disgusted you are. I'll save you the awkwardness of dumping me."

When I didn't move, she kicked me - quite hard - in the shin.

"Go on," she hissed. "Fuck off. I'd hoped you were different. I'd thought maybe - just maybe - you might be okay with this. That you might accept me for who I am. You said you'd fallen for me. But go, Ben. Just go."

"I'm not going anywhere," I said, rubbing my shin.

"What?" Jess wiped at the tears that were running down her cheeks.

"I'm not going anywhere," I repeated. "Not until I've told you something. My last secret that I've kept from you."

Jess didn't say anything. She blinked, rubbing at her eyes again. "Your last secret?" she said, sniffing and looking at me doubtfully.

I did have one thing I hadn't told her. The truth about my ex-wife Michelle and I. Tonight had changed everything. The way I saw Jess and the way I saw myself. The things that John had told me had resonated with my own past.

It was time to confront it.

Chapter 7

"My ex-wife, Michelle... I told you she cheated on me," I said but as I began to speak, Annabel stuck her head around the corner of our booth.

"Jess," she gave us both a pointed look. "You can't stay back here all night with your boyfriend."

"Shit," Jess looked at me with an exasperated expression. "I know it's important, whatever it is that you have to tell me, but it's going to have to wait a little while."

"Get out there and work the tables. There are customers wondering where you are," Annabel said, before disappearing back around the partition.

"Do I go out there or not?" Jess asked me, once the oriental woman had gone. "If you don't want me to, I won't. But if I don't, I'll probably lose this job and I don't know what I'll do."

"I told you, I'll look after you," I replied. "But it's up to you. If you say you do this because you enjoy it, then it wouldn't be fair of me to force you to quit - or be the cause of you getting sacked."

"We can finish this talk in an hour," Jess replied. "That's how long I usually work the tables for. Then we have a break before doing the stage a second time and then another round of tables before. Can you wait until the break? Please."

I really needed to tell her about Michelle but perhaps the hour she mentioned would give me time to phrase it properly in my head.

"Okay," I said, barely able to believe that I was going to let my girlfriend do this. She was going to give private dances to some of the customers in the room. "Are you going to... you know? With the guys out there..."

"Only if they want to," Jess reassured me. "Look, a lot of the time, they just want a dance. Sit with John for a while. He'll make you feel better."

She led me back out into the room and I immediately saw quite a few men watch me go back to my seat and then call out to Jezebel - her name here - for a dance.

"You don't look so great," John said as I joined him back at our table. "I take it that didn't go so well?"

"It's just a lot to take in at once." I sighed, puffing out my cheeks. "She confessed to doing it all, John. She gets guys off. She'd done all the private events at one time or another."

"The customers have to pay a lot to get into the events," John replied. "They're all wealthy guys, mostly businessmen. They're all respectable. The bouncers vet them all at the door. Anyone they don't know can't get in - even if they're willing to pay extra. Those that do get in - if they put so much as a foot out of line they get sorted out and barred from the club. With penetration, there's always condoms. The girls are safe, Ben. They get treated well and earn plenty. No one forces them to do anything they don't want to. I came to terms with it with Mel and maybe you can too."

I looked across at Jess, watching her as she smiled and giggled with an older, grey-haired, arabic-looking guy. She let him touch her ass as they walked over to the partitions, disappearing from view behind one of them.

"Where's Mel?" I asked John.

"Same place Jess is now," he shrugged. "Giving someone a private show. I'm going to get you a drink. A strong one. What's your poison?"

"Whisky," I replied gratefully. As I waited for him to return, I saw Mel emerge from the darkened corner of the room, her most recent customer returning to his seat while she moved to another set of tables, where a youngish guy signalled for her to come over. A few minutes later, she disappeared yet again to the private area, hand in hand with the youngster.

"Thanks," I said, taking the large whisky John held out when he came back. It was at least a double, if not more. I took a sip, my eyes watering because I wasn't used to spirits, but it felt good as it slid down my throat.

"Jess is done with that guy," he pointed across the room and I saw her doing the same thing Mel had just done - moving to another set of tables before giving her attention to one of the men calling out

her name. "Hey, it looks like she's going to give this guy a dance in his chair."

I took another sip of the whisky. I needed it because I was now watching Jess grind into her latest customer's lap, before turning around and lifting her top, baring her breasts to him so close that he'd be able to suck her nipples if he moved his head just a couple of inches closer. He didn't though. He kept his hands and his mouth to himself for the whole dance, which ended up with Jess totally naked in front of him.

"She's so fucking hot," John said, also watching Jess. "Honestly, if you can't handle her working here, I totally get it, but if you can see past all of this, what she does, I really think you have a great girl in Jess. She's funny, loyal, straight-talking and a great friend to Mel."

"I know how great she is," I sighed, watching both Mel and Jess almost simultaneously pick out their next two men and head over into the private booths with them. "Which is why this is so hard."

"Why what's so hard?" John looked at me out of the corner of his eye. "You're gonna ditch her, then?"

"I haven't told Jess this yet," I necked the rest of the whisky, then grimaced at the sting of it hitting the back of my nose. "I was going to - just now - but Annabel interrupted us."

"Go ahead," John said, watching me carefully. "You can tell me anything. I've told you everything about Mel and I, so you know I'm not going to judge."

"I was married before. Divorced now," I shook my head, not really wanting to relive these memories, but I'd repressed them for so long, perhaps this would be cathartic for me. "Michelle cheated on me. I caught her fucking her boss in the car park where she worked."

"That sucks, man," John said. "I'm sorry." He passed me one of the four beers he'd bought at the same time as the whisky.

"Turns out her boss wasn't the first guy she'd cheated on me with," I went on. "I confronted her about it and she said that her boss was the only one. What she didn't know is that I'd done some detective work and discovered that he was just the latest in a long line of conquests. - and of course, then we had this huge fight."

John didn't comment. He just nodded and let me continue.

“Michelle said I wasn’t enough for her, not just sexually, but in every way. She was bored. She needed some adventure. She said she loved me - but that love just wasn’t enough. I never understood that, but I gave her another chance. No more guys. And she agreed.”

“But she didn’t stop?” John asked. “She carried on fooling around?”

I nodded. “You said earlier that you enjoy seeing Mel do stuff with other men. That you get off on it? Is that true?”

“I never expected to feel that way,” John’s eyes took on a faraway look. “I was furious when I found Mel working here. I agreed to let her do the event, just so I wasn’t causing a big scene, then intended to deal with everything afterwards but as I watched her jerk off and suck all these guys, I found myself getting turned on. It was like I was watching porn, but in the flesh. The only weird thing being that the pornstar was my wife. After all the guys had done cumming on her, she called me over and let me fuck her. Dwayne - the big bodyguard you met earlier? He watched us fuck. And I can honestly say it was the most erotic experience of my life, up to that point. It changed me.”

“So you watch her all the time now?” I asked, trying to work through my own feelings. “And it turns you on. Does Mel get turned on by it too?”

“I watch. Sometimes I join in,” John admitted. “But it *a/ways* turns me on. I know you probably don’t get it, but it’s how it is. I’m not the only guy that feels this way. I did some online research - to try and understand - and it’s a popular thing. Cuckolding. Hotwives. There’s a whole scene out there of people who enjoy it.”

“I do get it,” I admitted. John’s head turned to look at me, one eyebrow raised in interest. “You see, after Michelle and I had the row and she promised to be faithful in future, then broke her promise, I never told her that I knew. She was still seeing guys but she switched to finding them online, probably thinking that I wouldn’t be able to find out that way. These guys were all much more discrete - most of them from out of town. But I logged into her email, guessed her passwords on the dating sites she used and I found out everything. And it got me horny.”

“Ah, I see,” John smiled. “So you let her carry on and you got off on reading their emails afterwards. Something like that?”

“I felt so ashamed and humiliated but yeah,” I admitted, feeling my cheeks redden. “At that time, I put it down to my brain somehow dealing with the hurt by turning it into something pleasurable. Turning a negative into a positive in order to cope. I don’t know. I did some online research - like you - I learned about the cuckolding fetish and the couples that practice it, but I couldn’t accept it. I let it go on for a year, Michelle screwing random guys every week or so, in hotel rooms, at their places, even in our own bed while I was at work. Then I just decided I’d had enough. I didn’t want to be a cuck. Maybe I should have talked to Michelle about it. Perhaps if I’d been man enough to admit to this side of me, we could have made it work. But I couldn’t. I was scared that she’d see me as pathetic. I didn’t want her to see me in that way, but of course, with hindsight, I recognise that she already did. I had nothing to lose. But I let her go. We divorced and to this day, I regret the way I dealt with it.”

“Wow,” John sat up in his seat. “That’s rough. Thanks for telling me. I guess dealing with something like that can’t have been easy. No wonder your head is all over the place tonight.”

“It’s almost like it’s happening all over again,” I said. “I’ve been afraid of commitment ever since. I put it down to distrust of women, blaming it on the fact that I’m fairly well-off financially. I always wonder if the women like me or my bank balance, but the more I think about it, the more I wonder if I’m just afraid of what happened with Michelle happening again. Not because I don’t want to be cheated on - but because I’m scared of feeling excited by it.”

“Are you horny now?” John asked. “Knowing that Jess is probably jerking or sucking some stranger off right at this moment?”

I looked at him and our eyes met. I couldn’t answer.

“I am,” John continued. “By the time our girls come over here - which should be any time now - they’ll probably have made at least two or three guys cum each. That gets me so fucking aroused. I can admit to it. It took me a while, but I can admit to it. Can you?”

He took a drink of his beer, breaking eye contact so he could look around the room. I followed his gaze and saw first Mel, then Jess, re-

emerge from the shadowy corner where they'd been with their most recent customers. The two girls saw each other, then together they headed our way. The hour was up already.

"What if it all goes wrong again?" I asked quietly, making John look at me quizzically. "Yes, it turns me on, just like it did with Michelle, but what if it all ends like it did with Michelle too? What if it ends with me being hurt and confused?"

"It's a risk," John admitted with a sympathetic nod. "One you have to decide if you want to take, or not."

My cock was hard. It had been the whole time I'd been watching Jess go in and out of the booth with different men. I'd hidden this truth from myself - that I enjoyed being cuckolded. It had reared its ugly head the moment I'd found about Brett and now it wasn't just rearing its head, it was biting me on the ass and demanding I deal with it.

Jess smiled at me nervously as the two girls reached John and I. She looked at the empty whisky glass and the numerous empty bottles littering the table top.

"You're *still* here," she said.

I was still here. I could have upped and ran at any time. John would have let me go, I knew that now. But I hadn't.

It was time. Time to face my demons. Time to decide what to do about Jess.

Chapter 8

"Are there any drinks left for us?" Mel surveyed all the bottles in front of her as she sat down next to John.

"These two are still full." John passed two beers - the last two out of the ones he'd bought - to Mel and Jess. She sat next to me, somewhat hesitantly, probably nervous of what I was going to do or say, now that she was back.

"Do you still want to talk to me?" Jess asked, tentatively putting a hand on my arm.

"You should tell her what you just told me," John suggested softly. "Don't worry about Mel. Like me, she'll understand."

"What is it?" Jess asked again when I didn't say anything straight away. I moved my arm, instead taking her hand in mine.

"I told John what I'd been going to tell you," I started slowly. "Right before Annabel turned up. Just telling him has actually made me feel slightly better about it."

"Tell us," Mel said to me gently, glancing at her husband, who smiled at her and nodded for some reason.

"My ex-wife, Michelle, cheated on me," I said, starting off the story and then it all came out, just as it had with John, but this time with more detail. Now I'd already said this stuff out loud once, it was much easier the second time. As I went away from what had happened and instead began to move into my feelings - of betrayal and humiliation but also excitement and arousal and the sense of shame that came with that - I felt Jess squeeze my hand and saw Mel and John once again share a look between them. This time I recognised it as an understanding of everything I was saying.

"I'm sorry that happened to you," Jess said, after a moment of awkward silence once I'd finished baring my soul. "And I'm sorry that I've put you through all of this but does this mean... maybe... we can try to make this work?"

"I'm willing to give it a try," I replied, with an emotionally-exhausted smile. "I told John that this feels like I'm risking getting hurt again. That I'm risking messing my head up like I did last time."

"I told him that he has to decide if the risk is worth it," John said.

“And I think you’re a risk worth taking,” I concluded, turning back to Jess.

Jess’s large blue eyes gazed into mine for a second then she leaned in and kissed me, making Mel sigh in happiness.

“I think I know what this calls for,” Mel said, when Jess and I finally stopped kissing.

“Champagne?” John suggested. “If so, Mr Moneybags here will have to pay because I’ve run up quite a bar tab.”

“Are you thinking what I’m thinking?” Jess said when Mel shook her head at John.

The two women leaned over the table, putting their heads together and whispering before giggling and turning back to their respective men.

“Follow me,” Jess said as she and Mel stood up, the dark-haired woman saying the same thing to her husband.

“What’s going on?” I asked him as the two girls led us across the room, towards the private area.

“I have no idea,” he replied, giving me a shrug as the women took us around the corner and into the same booth I’d been in an hour or so before. I sat down on the leather seat and John did the same, while our two women stood before us with mischievous grins on their faces.

“This will cost you five tokens each,” Jess held her hand out. “I know John bought you some, you showed me earlier.”

I counted out five and John did the same, passing them to Mel. “What are we paying for?” he asked.

“For as long as I can remember, you’ve been asking me for a double-dance with Jess,” his wife replied. “I’ve always said ‘no’ because Jess is my friend.”

“Mel has never let me do a dance for him in all this time,” Jess said to me. “The night he found out about Mel working here, he made me do a naked dance for him and he even asked me to suck his cock but I wouldn’t. I knew he wanted some sort of revenge, blaming me for Mel being here.”

“She told me about it afterwards,” Mel continued. “And I was furious that he’d put my best friend in that position. So I made him

promise never to ask Jess for a dance. She is off-limits.”

“But that didn’t stop him asking for a double-dance,” Jess finished off the story. “Again, Mel has always said ‘no’. However...”

“However,” Mel took over, starting to dance to the music which had stopped as we were walking over to the booths, but now restarted just at the right moment. “Seeing as we have something to celebrate - namely Ben accepting Jess working here - I think we just changed our minds, didn’t we, Jess?”

“We did,” my girlfriend said, pushing her purple-brown hair over her shoulder and smiling at me. “Would you like a dance, Ben?”

“A double-dance,” Mel added.

“Fuck yeah, we do,” John answered for me, rubbing his hands together.

Jess moved in close, pushing my thighs apart and turned away, bending over so that her ass was pushing against me. My cock was already hard, but the sensation of her grinding on to me like that made it even harder. I looked sideways to see Mel doing the same to John and then, to my surprise, the two girls switched places.

“Oh, Jesus,” John breathed as Jess grinned at him, then bent over again and rubbed her backside on his groin as Mel did the same to me.

Mel’s behind was even firmer than Jess’s and looked amazing in the tiny silver panties she was wearing. She must have been able to feel my erection as she slid her ass over my lap, but she didn’t say anything.

Then our girls stood up and in one smooth movement, they both discarded their tops; Jess lifting hers over her head and Mel simply unclasping hers before turning so that her modest tits were right in front of my face, so close that she should have been able to feel my heavy breaths blowing over them. John’s wife’s nipples were dark and erect and it took me a moment to tear my eyes from them to look at him admiring Jess’s larger boobs from a similarly short distance away.

Again, the girls swapped places and this time as they did so, they removed their bottoms, Jess slowly and sensually discarding the shiny pink shorts as I watched. Then she slid towards me, pushing

my knees back together and sitting on my lap. I could feel the heat of her pussy through the trousers I was wearing.

"Kiss me," she murmured, but just as our lips touched, she nipped mine between her teeth then giggled and pulled away, teasing me.

The two women again changed places, Mel now bending over in front of me so that I could see her tight-looking shaved pussy from behind. Again, I looked sideways to see John's eyes almost popping out of his head as Jess did the same.

"I've wanted to see that pussy close-up again for so long," he muttered. "Ben. What do you think of Mel's body?"

I looked at Jess, suddenly feeling awkward but my girlfriend was just watching me with a huge smile on her face, obviously finding my discomfort amusing.

"Amazing," I said, although to be truthful, I preferred Jess's more plentiful curves. Mel's body *was* amazing though. I wasn't lying. She was fit and toned and incredibly sexy.

"How many cocks have you sucked tonight, baby?" John then asked his wife, who was now rubbing her bare pussy against my aching groin.

"Just one," Mel replied. "I did jerk two guys off though. One had a really nice big dick too. I was tempted to sit on it."

"Do you want to know about me?" Jess asked, as the two women switched places yet again.

"Yes," I croaked, doing my best not to cum in my pants.

"I sucked two and played with one," Jess said, looking over her shoulder at me. "Again, one had a nice cock. The other two were quite small, but they were okay. I don't mind small ones sometimes."

"Did you make them cum?" I breathed. This was incredible.

"Two on my tits, one in my mouth," Jess replied.

I groaned. It was almost too much. "Fuck," I heard myself mumble as she turned and straddled me, her pussy hot as it settled over my erection.

"Does it really turn you on?" she whispered sexily into my ear. When I nodded, she nibbled on my ear and kissed my neck, then

spoke again, this time louder, loud enough for John and Mel to hear. "Would you like to watch me suck John's cock?"

I looked at John to see Mel straddling him but they were both still, watching us, waiting for my answer.

"Okay," I nodded. This was unreal.

"Really?" John's eyes were glistening with excitement.

"Fuck it," Mel shrugged. "Why not?" Then she swapped places with Jess one more time, sitting on my knee while Jess knelt down between John's legs and undid his jeans.

"This is a one-off thing," Jess told Mel's husband as she pulled out his already-erect dick. "Don't expect it all the time." Then I watched as her lips wrapped around the large, swollen head of his penis before sliding down so that he was fully inside her mouth.

"Shit, this is horny." Mel fidgeted on my knee, then let one hand slide down to begin rubbing my erection through my trousers. I was much smaller than John, so I felt too embarrassed to ask her for a blow job. Besides, it was the two women here setting the rules. It'd be rude to ask. I just let her rub me as we watched my girlfriend suck John's cock.

Within a few minutes, John had his hands in Jess's hair and was humping his hips upwards, thrusting into her mouth and I could tell he was close to cumming. Jess pulled away, holding his throbbing cock in her hand while turning to Mel and I.

"I actually feel like fucking him," she gasped to us, wiping some of John's pre-cum from her chin.

"Mel," John said to his wife. "Do you want to fuck Ben? I'd love to see you do him, if it's okay with Jess."

"It's okay with me," Jess said, straddling John without even waiting for Mel's greenlight to do so. As I watched John position his bulbous bell-end at the entrance to my girlfriend's pussy, I felt Mel tugging down my trousers. I flinched, waiting for a comment on my smaller-than-average size but none came. Mel climbed onto the couch, hovered her tight slit over my dick which was pointing straight upwards because it was so hard, then she slid down to it, just as Jess did the same to John.

Mel's mouth closed over mine and we kissed as I let her ride me but I didn't last long. I was already close before we'd even started, so I whispered in her ear that I was going to cum and she dismounted with a smug grin and instead stroked my cock until I came all over my stomach.

I looked sideways and saw that Jess was bent over on the leather sofa next to us. John was standing behind her, ramming his fat cock into her with gusto until after a couple more minutes, he too came, pulling out and spraying my girlfriend's curvy ass with thick white cum.

Mel passed me and John a couple of wet-wipes from a pouch on the side of the sofa and I cleaned myself up the best I could while trying to mentally recover from what had just happened.

"This is a fucking dream come true," John was saying to his wife as the two women laughed at him. "Please say we can do this again. Maybe at our place. Or Ben's, if he's up for it."

"That's up to Ben," Jess said, putting her shiny pink top and bottoms back on and then sitting on my lap after I'd pulled up and refastened my trousers. She kissed me and I responded, kissing her back passionately even though I could taste John's pre-cum on her lips.

"Say yes," implored Mel. "I want a tour of this place of yours. Jess tells me you've even got a swimming pool."

"And a Porsche," John added, as we made our way out of the booths and back to our seats.

"Can we take this one step at a time?" I asked as we sat down. "My head is still spinning from what just happened."

"I love you, Ben," Jess said. "Yes, I just used the 'L word', and I meant it."

I looked from Jess to Mel and John. They were sitting down, watching us and listening again, waiting to see what I'd say.

"I love you too," I said, knowing it was true. Again, Mel sighed at the romanticism of it all.

"I promise. I won't hurt you like Michelle did," Jess said, beaming from ear to ear. "We can make this work. I'm sure of it. This time you have John to talk to about your feelings so you won't have to bottle

them up like you did before. We won't end up like you and Michelle did. I know it. I've got a man who loves me and who can accept what I do. Like John does with Mel. That's what I've wanted for so long and now I've got it, I'm not going to let you go."

"Okay," I said with an equally wide smile, feeling truly optimistic after what she'd just said. "Let's do this."

Epilogue

“Jess?” I called out as I got out of the pool. She didn’t reply, so she must have decided against joining me for a swim after all. I stretched, enjoying the feeling of the warm spring sunlight through the windows that overlooked the back garden of my home. Jess had moved in with me a week after that night at the Black Cats Club and we hadn’t looked back since.

Our relationship had gone from strength to strength over the past six months. Jess had taken a week off from working at the strip club as we discussed our relationship and how it was going to work. Once we’d agreed on a few things - I was Mr Organised; I liked rules - she moved in and I let her return to work.

Our rules were simple. I didn’t want her to have sex with anyone outside of what happened at the club, unless it was something we arranged together. We did another foursome with Mel and John that same week; the first of many we’d done since then. Because we were more relaxed and in a more comfortable environment, we’d been able to take our time in getting to know each other’s wives better and the sex between the four of us was incredible. Both Jess and Mel were on the pill, so we even came inside each other’s women, something that I found incredibly erotic.

Another rule was that Jess had to report to me how many men she’d made cum every night that she worked. I enjoyed hearing the details as she broke it down for me into how many handjobs she’d given, how many blowjobs, how big the men’s dicks were and anything else I wanted to know.

Since we’d been together, she hadn’t done the Nine Lives gangbang night. We’d decided that was something I needed to be a part of and the opportunity hadn’t arisen yet, although it would one day. She *had* participated in the bukkake night and the glory hole event, and on one particular occasion, she’d let a customer fuck her, albeit with a condom. She liked the look and size of his large black cock and had just made a spur of the moment decision to put it inside her, much to the delight of the man on the other side of the glory hole wall.

“Jess?” I called out as I walked into the kitchen. As I’d wrapped a robe around me and left the pool room, I’d smelled food and so naturally had assumed she was either cooking or was eating in the dining room but she wasn’t to be found in either room.

I wandered upstairs, following the delicious smell and found the still-warm food; two half-eaten toasted sandwiches on a plate atop the dressing table in our master bedroom.

“I should have known,” I said to Jess, startling her from what she was doing. She turned her head and grinned at me.

“I was hungry but then Brett offered me a different snack,” she said, then returned to sucking Brett’s large hard cock.

Her ex-husband was on his back on our bed, completely naked, as was my girlfriend. “If you’re hungry,” he said to me, “You can finish the sandwiches. I’m about to make sure Jess is full of something else.”

I watched as he lifted Jess up in his huge arms and laid her down on her back. He eased her thighs apart and positioned himself over her, then shoved his cock inside her as I sat down on the dressing gown chair and helped myself to one of the sandwiches, settling down to watch, as I often did when they had sex.

It made sense for Brett to move in. We had three spare bedrooms, one for him to sleep in and one which I converted into a gym for him and Jess to use. The exercise became a good distraction from the drugs. Now, some four months after he’d moved in, he was almost totally clean, only having the occasional relapse and even then it was only a line or two of cocaine. He was off the harder stuff entirely, and between what Jess earned at the club and the extra amount I’d helped with, we’d paid off the drug dealers that he’d owed money to.

I loved watching him fuck her. It was horny to hear about Jess’s sexual encounters at the club, but getting to watch her with Brett was the ultimate thrill. I loved experiencing how he could make her orgasm on his dick, something I could never do with my inferior member.

The two of them would often tease me about my smaller penis, but it was always done with humour and again, it was something I’d

learned to embrace. Jess still enjoyed having sex with me - we did it once or twice a week - nowhere near the amount that she and Brett fucked, which was every day at least once, but it was enough for me. I got almost as much satisfaction from jerking off while watching them fuck as I did actually having sex, so I was happy.

When they'd finished fucking; after Jess had a huge orgasm and Brett had shot his load inside her, he headed for a shower, leaving Jess and I alone. I'd finished eating the sandwich and rubbed the crumbs off my chin before kissing her lightly on the lips.

She opened her tilted blue eyes and smiled at me.

"Hey," she said.

"Hey yourself," I smiled back. "You know something?"

"What?" she said.

"That day we met," I said, feeling oddly nostalgic. "At the fountain..."

"I remember," she smiled again. Jess had the most amazing smile. "You turned up. I wasn't sure you would," she repeated the words she'd said that day.

"I'm glad I did," I said softly, then I slid down, kissing over her body to lick Brett's cum out of her. Something she loved. As did I. I'd become the thing I'd been afraid of all those years ago when Michelle had cheated on me. I'd become a true cuckold. I knew that now.

For years I'd battled with the suppressed knowledge of what I was. I'd hidden those emotions away, chasing them into dark corners, like a game of cat and mouse.

But now the cat had caught the mouse and eaten it.

I licked my lips. It tasted delicious.

A Note to the Reader

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Until next time,

Paul

About the Author

Paul Garland is a Sheffield, UK based author of erotic novels and short stories, guaranteed to keep you turning the lust-filled pages until the early hours of the night.

Paul has been writing since the turn of the millennium but only turned to the erotica genre in 2018 with his *Cerulean Erotica Presents* series and *No Angels* series of books which rapidly gained him a following. In 2020, he began '*The Cuckold Collection*,' a brand new collection of cuckold-themed books and two new series of shorter stories: *The No Angels Shorts* and *The Sexy Season Shorts* and has yet another as-yet-untitled series in the works for 2021.

His website is [here](#). It's got his blog and a link to all of his books.

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